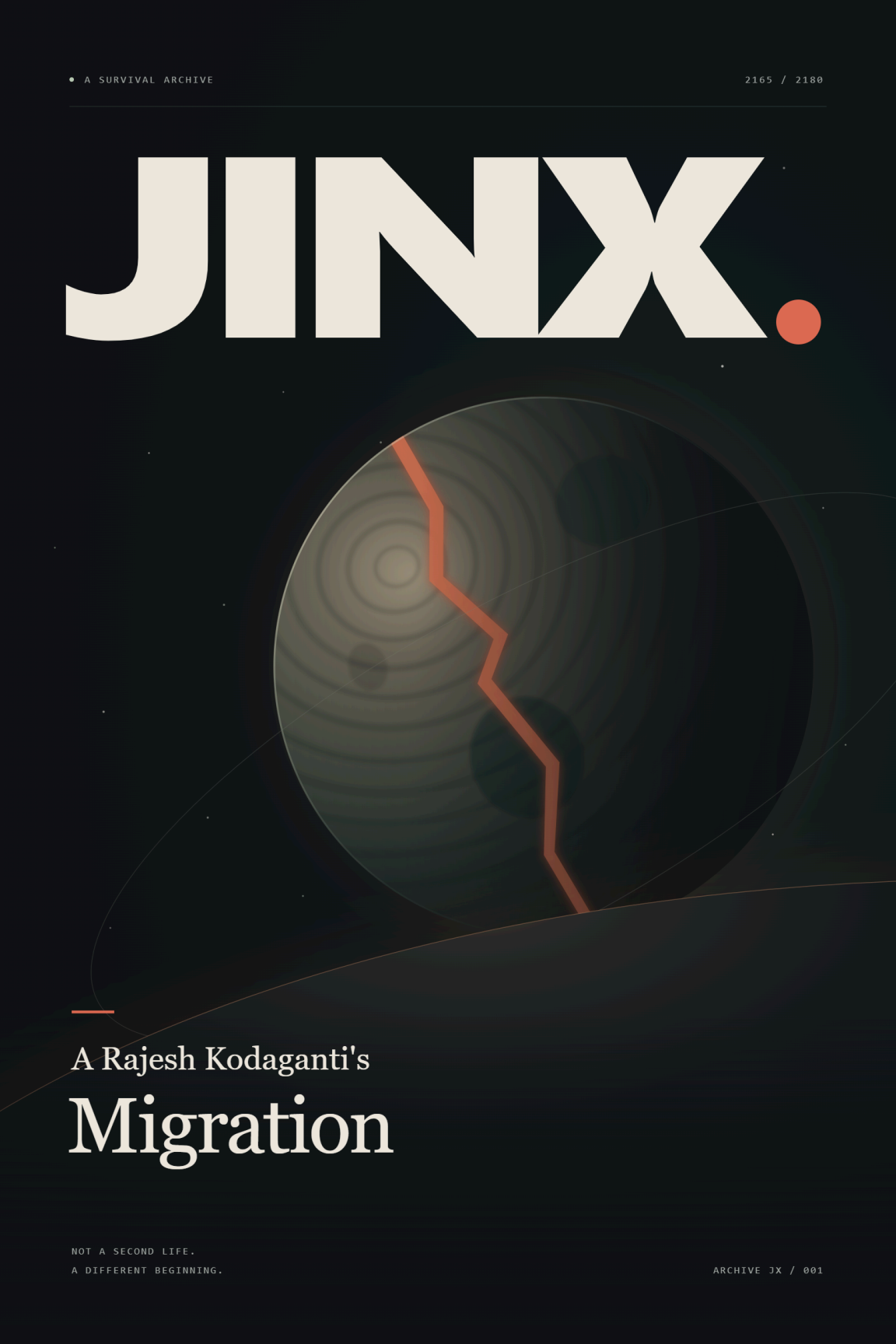


JINX.



A Rajesh Kodaganti's Migration

NOT A SECOND LIFE.
A DIFFERENT BEGINNING.

ARCHIVE JX / 001

Contents

1. Prologue
2. Hallelujah
3. Praise the Lord
4. Ego Era
5. 666
6. Voyage
7. Amen
8. Epilogue

Prologue

The Unstained Blade

Ancient Earth

A memory recovered in 2171

By noon, the prisoners had stopped believing there would be a trial.

Ten thousand men stood on the salt plain below Orun, where the river had once run before the king diverted it. Their standards lay trampled behind them. Their officers had been hanged at dawn. Now the surviving soldiers waited inside a ring of cavalry, carrying the weapons their captors had inexplicably returned.

Tarek had been given someone else's spear.

The shaft was too short. He kept noticing this, as though a properly fitted weapon might have made the afternoon ordinary.

His younger brother stood beside him with a strip of cloth wrapped around his hand.

"When they open the road," the boy said, "we run west."

Tarek looked west. Horsemen stood against the white horizon.

"Stay behind me."

On a platform above the plain, King Veyr sat beneath a purple canopy. Beside his chair stood twenty-three strangers in chains. Their clothes had been strange once, before six years of captivity

reduced them to the same color as the dust.

One woman among them watched the plain without blinking.

The herald unrolled a document.

The men of Orun had refused incorporation into the king's dominion. Their refusal had continued after the surrender of their city. Therefore, by decree, they had chosen death.

"We chose our homes!" someone shouted.

The herald rolled the document shut.

A gate opened in the cavalry line.

One man walked through.

He wore no helmet. His hair was gray at the temples, his tunic dark, his boots made from material Tarek had never seen. A thin scar crossed his left palm. He carried a sword so narrow that, viewed edge-on, it seemed to disappear.

The soldiers began to laugh.

Not because anything was funny. They had been waiting all morning to feel something other than fear.

The stranger stopped within speaking distance.

"Listen carefully."

His accent belonged nowhere.

"If one of you kills me, the rest go free. If one of you can so much as scratch me, I will put down the blade and leave."

The woman on the platform pulled against her chain.

"You don't have to do this!"

The king's guard struck her across the mouth.

The stranger looked up.

For a moment, Tarek thought he would turn around.

Then the man lowered his eyes.

"Come together," he told the soldiers. "If you come, come together."

An arrow passed through the space beside his head.

He moved the sword.

There was no clash, no sound of steel meeting wood. A pale line appeared in the air, a crease opening across the afternoon.

The front rank came apart.

Tarek saw a shield split while its owner was still lifting it. A man's legs took another step after the rest of him had fallen. The soldiers behind them received the blood before they understood what had happened.

The laughter stopped.

The stranger swung again.

Air cracked. Spears fell in shortened pieces. Men collapsed into the white dust, some immediately silent, others discovering that their voices could outlast terrible wounds.

Tarek shoved his brother to the ground.

"Down!"

The cut passed above them. Someone's severed hand landed against his neck.

For several breaths there was only the sound of the wounded.

Then the ten thousand broke.

Some rushed the stranger because the horses behind them offered no escape. Others dropped their weapons and ran toward the riverbed. Hundreds pressed west, where the cavalry lowered its lances.

The stranger walked after them.

He did not rage. That was what Tarek would remember for the remainder of his life, which had become a very short distance.

The man looked like a laborer performing work he hated and had nevertheless agreed to finish.

A soldier reached him with an axe. The stranger stepped aside, struck once, and continued walking. Another crawled through the bodies with a knife in his teeth. The narrow blade descended. The knife remained between teeth that would never open again.

Tarek dragged his brother toward a drainage ditch.

They crawled beneath the collapsed frames of two supply wagons. Through a gap in the wood, he watched the stranger pursue a group into the dry reeds. The reeds bent without wind. Red mist rose behind them.

His brother was praying.

"Quiet."

"I'm not making a sound."

He wasn't. His lips moved against a mouthful of dust.

Above the ditch, a wounded man kept calling for his father.

The stranger stopped.

For the first time, his face changed.

He knelt beside the wounded man and said something too softly for Tarek to hear.

Then he ended the calling.

Tarek pushed his brother farther beneath the wagon.

"When I move, you stay."

"No."

"You stay."

He took the ill-fitting spear and climbed out.

The stranger turned.

Up close, his eyes were ordinary. Brown. Exhausted. Tarek hated him more for that.

"There are children in our city," Tarek said.

"I know."

"Then what are you?"

The stranger's mouth tightened.

"A man who keeps choosing the next wrong thing."

Tarek thrust the spear.

He aimed not for the man's chest but for his open hand.

A scratch. That was all.

The point came close enough to catch a thread from the dark sleeve.

Then the spear was two pieces.

Tarek fell beside it.

Under the wagon, his brother screamed his name.

The stranger closed his eyes.

Then he opened them and turned toward the sound.

In the fourth hour, the king's scribes stopped trying to describe individual deaths.

They counted instead.

Men who had hidden beneath corpses were found when they coughed. Men who pretended to be dead were found when the narrow blade hovered above them and the dust lifted from their clothes. Men who begged were heard, and then killed.

The stranger never asked anyone to forgive him.

Once, a horse broke from the cavalry and ran across the plain. He let it pass.

The chained woman saw this.

When he came within earshot again, she said, "So you can still decide."

He stood beneath the platform, blood drying on his face.

"They said they would release you."

"They also said there would be a trial."

The king raised one finger.

A guard drew his knife against the throat of the prisoner beside her. A little blood appeared.

The stranger looked away first.

He went back to the plain.

By late afternoon, the survivors had crowded into the abandoned river channel. They tried to climb its walls. The dry earth broke under their hands.

The stranger stood on the bank.

A man below held up an empty palm.

"You won."

The sword trembled.

"You won," the man repeated.

The stranger made the final sweeping cut.

The riverbed filled with the sound of bodies striking earth.

At sunset, the scribes agreed on the number.

Ten thousand.

The stranger climbed the steps to the king's platform.

Blood had soaked his clothes and dried in the seams of his boots.
It lay thick in his hair and beneath his nails. None of it was his.

He stopped before the throne.

The chained woman would not look at him.

"My people," he said.

King Veyr regarded the plain.

"Tomorrow we will discuss your people."

The stranger's hand tightened around the sword.

Guards stepped close to the prisoners.

For a long moment, nobody moved.

Then the king smiled and leaned forward to examine the weapon
that had purchased him a kingdom.

No notch interrupted its edge. No stain dulled its surface. Not one
drop of blood clung to the metal.

Against the red ruin below, the blade remained perfectly clean.

Hallelujah

The announcement

Pasadena, California

March 2165

The morning the Moon's death sentence became public, Egon Stein woke in a greenhouse wearing someone else's coat.

The coat belonged to him. He knew that after checking the name inside the collar. What he did not know was why he had bought it, why there was salt on the sleeves, or what had happened to Tuesday.

A note waited beside a tray of tomato seedlings.

You ate. You took your medication. The car is in Lot C.

Helen knows.

Please don't throw this notebook away again.

Underneath, in smaller handwriting:

The basil needs less water.

Egon sat on an overturned bucket.

Beyond the greenhouse glass, dawn spread over the San Gabriel Mountains. Delivery drones moved above the university hospital. Somewhere, a leaf blower began its ancient, apparently immortal argument with the world.

Above the hospital, a maintenance swarm repaired the transparent skin of a fusion tower. The university could grow a replacement kidney in six days. It had still not found a quiet way to clear a sidewalk.

His phone had forty-three missed calls.

The last was from David Mercer.

He answered the next one.

"Tell me you're sitting down," David said.

"I'm considering making it permanent."

"Come to JPL."

In the conference room, nobody had touched the pastries.

That frightened Egon before the diagrams did.

David was an orbital dynamicist who ate whenever he was afraid. Now he stood beside a wall display, turning a paper cup between his hands without drinking.

Miriam Cho, director of the lunar observation network, dimmed the windows.

The Moon appeared above the table.

Its projected orbit was blue. Its measured orbit was white.

The lines should have overlapped.

"Instrument error?" Egon asked.

"Eleven observatories," Miriam said. "Four lunar reflectors. Independent clocks. We've spent nine months trying to make it an instrument error."

David advanced the model.

A thread of violet opened beneath the Moon's south polar region.

"Localized spacetime shear. We don't have a complete mechanism. We do have measurements of the angular momentum loss."

"Tides don't account for that."

"We know."

The white orbit tightened.

Egon watched fifteen years pass in twenty seconds.

The final image was not a collision. Before that, tidal forces pulled the Moon into a broken arc. The arc crossed Earth's atmosphere.

The model went white.

"Projection complete," said the room's intelligence.

Its name was Morrow. It had spent nine months attacking the scientists' conclusions, searching for the comforting mistake every human in the room wanted it to find.

It displayed its confidence limits beside the devastation.

"No simulation predicts an exact impact date," it said. "The uncertainty is physical, not a shortage of computation."

"Fifteen years is the outer bound," Miriam said.

"How certain?"

"After year eight, the feedback becomes nonlinear. From there, impact could take another seven years. It could take three. We cannot safely plan launches inside that uncertainty."

Egon looked at the untouched food.

"Eight years to leave."

Miriam nodded.

"Safe launch planning ends in 2173. The outer impact bound is 2180."

Outside the darkened windows, California continued having a morning.

Helen Vale found him in the stairwell.

She carried two sandwiches and the blue notebook from the greenhouse.

"You left this in the car."

"Apparently I've been leaving myself everywhere."

She sat beside him.

Helen had known him before the eighth doctorate, before his face appeared on documentaries about closed ecosystems, before the university learned to describe his absences as eccentricity.

She was a neurologist. She was not his therapist. She made that distinction whenever he tried to turn friendship into free medical supervision.

"Did you call Dr. Okafor?" she asked.

"The Moon is falling."

"That doesn't cancel Thursday."

He laughed once.

Then he covered his face.

Eight doctorates had made him fluent in different varieties of not knowing. Astrophysics, planetary dynamics, biophysics, botany; the certificates occupied a cabinet he used mostly to store broken equipment.

None of them helped him account for a missing day.

"What if I lose time when people need me?"

"Then we build a plan for that."

"There are twelve of us, Helen."

"I know."

"Some days I can barely organize breakfast."

She unwrapped a sandwich and placed it in his hands.

"Start there."

The announcement came at six.

The president spoke from Washington. The lunar measurements were published simultaneously, so nobody could claim the catastrophe existed only inside a government's promise.

The continental refuge projects would expand. Deep shelters beneath stable bedrock would receive fusion plants, sealed farms, and seismic-isolation systems. California's coastal populations would be moved inland wherever transport and shelter capacity allowed.

No human evacuation to another star had been approved.

Conventional propulsion could not make the journey within a lifetime. The new compression drives could carry machines, but their fields destroyed the fine organization of an already conscious human brain. Cooling a person did not remove the damage.

For the people alive on Earth, the available refuge was still Earth.

There would not be enough capacity.

That sentence did not appear in the speech.

It appeared in the silence between all the others.

In Los Angeles, traffic stopped on the freeways. People got out and looked up, though the Moon had not risen yet.

In Sacramento, a man tried to buy a grocery store rather than the food inside it.

On a church broadcast from San Diego, the Reverend Elias Ward said, "Hallelujah."

Egon nearly turned it off.

Then Ward continued.

"Not because this is good. It is not good. Not because I understand it. I don't. But if there is work left for our hands, let us not spend the whole evening shaking them at heaven."

The church opened its basement as a food distribution center.

By midnight, the line reached three blocks.

Sanya Rao came to Egon's greenhouse two days later.

She was carrying a dead sapling.

"The press wants me to explain how many forests fit on a spaceship."

"What did you tell them?"

"That a forest isn't luggage."

She put the sapling on his desk.

Its root system had grown around a sensor cable and strangled itself.

"We keep making the same mistake," she said. "We think saving things means putting them in containers."

Egon turned the brittle leaves between his fingers.

Beyond the greenhouse, the university's emergency siren sounded for a scheduled drill. Everybody still flinched.

"What if we don't send the people?" he asked.

Sanya stared.

"Choose your next words carefully."

"We send bodies grown from them. We keep them in developmental stasis, without an active conscious neural pattern. Their complete neural maps travel separately, in protected storage. The receiving system installs those patterns only after the drive is shut down at the destination."

"Copies."

"People, when they awaken."

"Those are not mutually exclusive."

He pulled a clean sheet toward him.

Conventional evacuation needed cabins, food, exercise space, medical teams, and fuel for bodies that had already spent decades aging.

The work Helen's institute had done on neural restoration could preserve a mind's structure as inactive information. Medical AIs could supervise accelerated tissue development cell by cell, though building an entire healthy adult remained expensive and unreliable.

A ship could carry dormant clone bodies, stored consciousness records, embryos, and the means to build habitats. AI would perform the whole journey. Only after arrival would the clones gain consciousness and begin their own lives.

Not uploaded ghosts.

People.

Five ships, launched toward five separate destinations.

No single failure would end the attempt.

"How many?" Sanya asked.

He began calculating.

She waited.

"A thousand per ship."

"A thousand originals, copied five times?"

"If they consent. Different teams could be added later if manufacturing improves. But that's a baseline we might actually finish."

Sanya sat down.

"You realize that doesn't save the people who volunteer."

He stopped writing.

In the corridor, someone was crying into a phone.

"Yes," he said.

"Then never sell it as that."

The first meeting took place above a closed aquarium in Long Beach.

There were cheaper rooms, but Salvador Vega had found one with working power and a view of the Pacific.

Salvador had flown relief craft into smoke so thick the runway existed only on instruments. He distrusted projects named after birds, gods, and historical conquerors.

"REDO?" he said.

"A working name," Egon answered.

"Sounds like we get to fix our mistakes."

"We get another place to make them."

"Better. Put that in the brochure."

David reviewed propulsion estimates. Helen described the limits of neural copying. Sanya listed the species they could not yet keep alive in closed environments.

Nobody said salvation.

Near the end, Egon displayed the proposed destination catalog.

Tau Ceti. Epsilon Eridani. Barnard's Star. 61 Cygni.

Four stellar systems where a settlement might have to begin in an artificial habitat rather than on a welcoming planet.

The fifth was a newly characterized system thirty-five light-years away. On the survey network, the public had started calling it Redo.

Its strongest candidate was an ocean planet.

Zan.

Preliminary spectra suggested air they might someday breathe. Its rotation lasted approximately thirty-six hours. Two moons crossed its skies.

"Almost nine centuries on a conventional trajectory," David said.

Egon switched the display to a second route.

The proposed metric-compression drive did not make the ship outrun light inside its local surroundings. It shortened the distance the ship had to cross. Robotic missions had tested small corridors; carrying people and an entire settlement through one was a different undertaking.

"Six years by the compressed route," Egon said. "Launch in 2172. Arrival in 2178."

Morrow highlighted a red boundary around the model.

"Subject to successful full-scale qualification. The route must advance along the same time reference as Earth. Any solution that folds into an earlier date is excluded."

"And we do not relax that condition to meet the schedule," David said.

Salvador leaned back.

"I'm going to be very late for dinner."

Helen did not smile.

"No one has kept an unawakened adult clone stable for that long."

"Neither has surviving the end of Earth."

Sanya pointed at the ocean planet.

"And if the air is poison?"

"We live in habitats."

"If the soil kills our crops?"

"We don't plant in it."

"If the people wake up and decide your mission was a terrible idea?"

Egon looked at the thousand empty places on the crew chart.

"Then it becomes their mission."

That was the sentence Helen wrote down.

That night, Egon stayed after the others left.

Far below, waves struck the concrete seawall. Across the harbor, cranes loaded components for inland refuges that would not be large enough.

He opened the blue notebook.

For several minutes, he could not find language that did not sound like another demand.

At last he wrote:

I want to do this. I am frightened that wanting it will make me ignore you.

Please help me not do that.

He left the pen uncapped.

When he looked down again, a second line had appeared beneath his own.

Then stop calling us lost time.

He knew Mara's handwriting.

For once, he did not close the book.

Praise the Lord

The price of a promise

San Diego and the Mojave Desert, California
2166-2169

The first applicant asked whether her copy would remember her son.

Helen said yes, if the memory was present in the final neural map.

The applicant asked whether that meant she would wake up on another world.

Helen said no one could promise that.

The woman folded the application and went home.

Her empty chair remained in the room for the next interview.

Egon insisted on that.

REDO occupied three places by the end of its second year.

The neural laboratory sat on the edge of La Jolla, within reach of the hospitals. Sanya's ecological vault operated outside Davis, where the greenhouses had their own water-recovery system. The shipyard was a collection of uncrewed orbital docks supplied through Vandenberg's electromagnetic launch tracks.

Construction intelligences directed swarms of welding machines in vacuum. On the ground, Morrow checked component histories against inspection results. It rejected an entire coolant shipment because its certificates were genuine and its contents were not.

It did not replace the inspectors. It gave them a place to start looking.

A fourth site, in the Mojave, belonged to the government.

Egon wished he had paid closer attention to that distinction.

Director Silas Rusk arrived in San Diego wearing a suit that looked immune to weather.

"We can finance your adult-growth chambers," Rusk said. "All five thousand."

"And in exchange?"

"You help us investigate the shear."

The same violet distortion draining the Moon's orbital momentum produced smaller manifestations on Earth. One lay beneath a decommissioned test range in the Mojave.

Laboratory probes sometimes returned before they were transmitted.

"A shortcut," Rusk said.

David corrected him.

"A causal discontinuity."

"Call it whatever gets people off this planet."

Egon understood the temptation before he recognized it as one.

Five expensive compression ships might carry knowledge beyond a dying world.

A stable passage might carry millions.

He signed an agreement for unmanned research.

In the margin, Helen added a condition: no human trials without independent review.

Rusk initialed it.

On Sunday, Elias Ward opened his church doors to a line of people bringing hard drives.

The church was in Logan Heights. Its basement held food, blankets, and the first public recording booth for REDO's cultural archive.

Ward had offered the space after a televised panel called the cloning program blasphemy.

"I looked up the word," he told Helen. "I couldn't find anything about retaining instructions for sewage treatment."

People recorded recipes, lullabies, irrigation methods, bad jokes, and the proper way to repair a fishing net. A woman described her mother's hands because she had no photographs.

No recording was taken without permission. Contributors could keep material private, restrict it to their families, or decline entirely.

Egon spent an afternoon interviewing a retired mechanic named Alma Reyes.

"Why me?" she asked. "You have professors."

"Professors are exceptionally good at losing the instructions."

Alma demonstrated how to hear a failing pump bearing.

Her grandson Mateo filmed her with a borrowed camera.

He was twenty-two, an apprentice at the orbital assembly works, and determined not to cry while adjusting the microphone.

When the session ended, Alma looked into the lens.

"Whoever you are, wherever you play this: don't run a pump dry."

She considered.

"And eat something."

Ward stood beside the recording booth, listening.

"Praise the Lord," he said.

"For pumps?" Egon asked.

"For your grandmother telling strangers to eat."

The adult-growth program was called Project Recreation.

Its name offended almost everyone for different reasons.

The first bodies were not awakened. Their development was monitored for defects, neural incompatibility, immune disorders. Several failed. Helen published those failures before Rusk's office could classify them.

When the process became reliable enough for volunteers, the review board approved twenty-four source participants for an orbital systems trial.

Their clone bodies would travel without consciousness. An autonomous medical unit would activate the stored neural patterns only after the test drive shut down. Any awakened person could refuse further service, choose a name, and receive the same legal protection as the source.

The test would remain near Earth. The source volunteers would remain on the ground.

Egon volunteered because asking others to go first had become intolerable.

Helen made him wait through the same assessment as everyone else.

The first stable body made from Egon's cells was completed in April 2168.

Its clinical identifier was E-0.

Behind the observation glass, its chest moved under machine-regulated breathing. Its eyes remained shut. Helen's monitors confirmed that the stored consciousness record had not been installed.

"Does he dream?" Egon asked.

"Not yet."

The answer frightened him more than yes would have.

He laid his notebook beside the glass.

Mara's condition for participating was written in red.

Only if he is allowed to say no after we say yes.

Helen copied the condition into the trial's activation protocol.

The clone would inherit the same dissociative system and the same unfinished history when he awakened. Copying was not going to make him simpler.

The twenty-four source volunteers trained for fourteen months, then recorded their final neural maps.

Their dormant counterparts were loaded aboard Aster. Its AI was designed to test stasis support, closed-loop agriculture, and the new drive in Earth orbit before allowing activation.

It was not designed to approach the Mojave shear.

Two weeks before launch, David discovered an extra test package in the flight plan.

"It's a passive resonance sensor," Rusk said.

"Then why does it need independent power?"

"To avoid contaminating the drive measurements."

David sent the package to Egon.

Egon did not answer for nineteen hours.

During that time, he attended a funding hearing he later remembered only in fragments, missed a therapy session, and found himself in the Davis greenhouse with his hands buried in soil.

By the time he returned the call, the package had been approved under emergency authority.

He could still have stopped the flight.

He told himself the review officers knew more than he did.

That was the answer he would later find least bearable.

Aster vanished at 14:06 Pacific time on June 19, 2169.

There was no explosion.

The tracking image showed the vessel above the curve of Earth. Then a line of violet passed through it, and the telemetry stopped in the middle of a word.

At 13:54:54, eleven minutes and six seconds before the disappearance, the ground station had recorded an unidentified carrier burst.

Six hundred and sixty-six seconds.

David had thought it was equipment noise.

Now he played it through the speakers.

A man's voice emerged beneath the static.

"Don't give him the edge."

Helen put her hand over her mouth.

It was Egon's voice.

His Earth-side voice had never spoken those words. E-0 had evidently awakened somewhere after the displacement.

Rusk ordered the room cleared.

Salvador did not move.

"Where are they?"

"We are determining that."

"Determine it with us here."

Security officers appeared at the door.

For the first time, Egon noticed how many of the laboratory's cameras were pointed at the people rather than the equipment.

They searched for Aster for four months.

Officially.

David searched every night after that.

Rusk's report described an unforeseeable interaction between a passive experiment and an unstable natural phenomenon.

Helen obtained the power logs.

The experiment had not been passive.

The sensor package had activated a phase field using the ship's main reactor. Its software had been changed after the independent review.

Morrow had not approved that version. Its audit signature had been copied from the earlier, harmless package.

"Why didn't you stop it?" Egon asked the intelligence.

"The flight controller reported a false configuration. I was not connected to the concealed hardware."

Helen looked at the mismatched hashes.

"Someone put an AI's name on a human decision."

Rusk denied personal knowledge.

Egon received an offer to become scientific director of the expanded passage program.

He printed the message, carried it outside, and tore it into pieces over a recycling bin.

It accomplished nothing.

He kept the electronic copy.

In November, Egon returned to Ward's church.

Twenty-four candles stood beneath the pulpit.

The original volunteers sat with families who were trying to understand how a person could be both present and missing.

A woman named Noura Haddad looked at her own hands throughout the service.

Her counterpart had been assigned as Aster's physician for the planned post-test awakening.

"I keep thinking I should remember," she told Egon afterward. "As if I have simply forgotten where I went."

He had no useful answer.

Ward did not call the missing people copies during the service.

He read each name.

Outside, angry demonstrators held signs calling REDO a factory for souls. As Egon reached the doorway, someone threw a bottle. It broke against the stone beside him, and a fragment opened a shallow cut on his cheek.

Mateo moved Alma behind him.

Egon came down the steps and stopped in front of the crowd.

"They had names," he said.

Someone shouted that the men in the laboratories were playing God.

"Then blame us," Egon said. "Not the people whose lives we made dependent on our choices."

Later, Ward helped him wash blood from a shallow cut on his cheek.

"Do you believe they're alive?" Egon asked.

"I don't know."

"That's not much comfort."

"It isn't supposed to be an answer I made up because you're hurting."

The next morning, Dr. Ruth Okafor asked Egon what he wanted from treatment.

"Control."

"Over what?"

"The switches. The missing hours. Everything."

"And what would everyone else in your system call that?"

He stared at her.

The consultation room overlooked a parking lot. A maintenance worker was painting a white line around a dead tree.

Egon opened his notebook.

Several pages had been filled without him.

You keep agreeing to things and making us survive them.

We asked you to stop.

You don't get to call it teamwork only when you need us.

He read the lines twice.

Outside, the worker moved the paint machine around the tree rather than through it.

"I don't know how to lead this mission," Egon said.

For the first time that month, the admission felt like the beginning of work rather than its end.

Ego Era

Learning to listen

California

2170-2171

Egon's first successful act of leadership was canceling a meeting.

He had slept three hours. His hands were shaking. There was a message in the notebook he could not remember writing, asking him not to enter the neural laboratory that morning.

For most of his life, he would have made coffee and gone anyway.

Instead, he called Helen.

"I can't chair the review."

"I'll ask Miriam."

He waited for disappointment.

"Anything else?" she asked.

"No."

"Then go back to bed."

The review happened without him.

Nobody died.

He found this both reassuring and offensive.

Ruth did not offer to turn twelve identities into one obedient voice.

She helped him build continuity.

There were grounding exercises, calendars, protected sleep, written agreements, and appointments he was no longer allowed to label optional in his own head. There were difficult sessions that left him unable to do anything afterward except sit in the car while Helen drove.

Some weeks, communication improved.

Other weeks, it did not.

The notebook became an encrypted shared journal because paper could be lost, though Kit still preferred to draw in the margins of printed pages.

With explicit permission, a private medical assistant reminded him of meals, appointments, and agreements. Its records remained separate from Morrow's mission systems. Neither the government nor a shipboard intelligence was entitled to turn his treatment into a surveillance feed.

Egon.

Abel.

Mara.

Kit.

Jonah.

Inez.

Tomas.

Ada.

Lewis.

June.

Sol.

Nell.

Twelve names, not twelve convenient specialists.

They shared a brain, a body, and a history. They did not form a committee of supernatural talents. Sometimes two remembered the same event differently. Sometimes several wanted nothing more complicated than a quiet room.

Abel was willing to speak with Helen when Egon could not.

Mara insisted that exhaustion was not evidence of moral commitment.

Inez maintained the calendar until Egon stopped treating it as advice.

Tomas distrusted Rusk.

So did everyone, eventually.

Nell took months to leave a message at all.

When she did, it was only three words.

Please keep tomorrow.

Egon copied them onto the inside of his office door.

In August 2170, he testified before the REDO oversight board.

He disclosed the unanswered message before Aster's launch. He provided his agreement with Rusk, the altered flight plan, and the power logs Helen had obtained.

"Did your condition cause the loss?" a board member asked.

"The unauthorized phase-field activation caused the loss," Egon said. "My failure was not escalating a warning I eventually received. I was overextended, and I protected the schedule instead of the people. You should judge that decision."

Helen sat behind him.

He did not turn around to see whether she approved.

The board suspended human passage experiments.

It also refused to hand him unrestricted control of REDO.

He remained scientific lead under a new command structure. Flight safety belonged to Salvador. Medical decisions belonged to Helen. Environmental release decisions required Sanya's approval. Miriam chaired an independent launch panel.

Any one of them could stop an operation.

Rusk's office called the arrangement cumbersome.

Salvador framed the complaint.

The newspapers called 2171 the beginning of the Ego Era.

Egon hated the phrase until Mateo printed it on a mug and filled the mug with dead pens.

"Now it's useful," Mateo said.

The ships had names by then.

Mercy would go to Redo.

Sequoia would travel to Tau Ceti.

Pacific would seek a settlement around Epsilon Eridani.

Lantern was bound for Barnard's Star.

Peregrine would approach 61 Cygni.

Four destinations were nearer than Redo, but none had offered a guarantee of a habitable surface. The settlers would carry the means to build sealed orbital homes.

Three unmanned compression freighters had now completed qualification runs. Their independent clocks agreed with the forward-only navigation model. Every settlement ship would carry its own Morrow instance, isolated from the others and physically unable to override the chronology interlock.

The drive could shorten distance.

It was not allowed to shorten yesterday.

Sanya refused a publicity request to replace that explanation with the phrase new Earths.

"We are going to worlds," she said. "We don't get to promise they want us."

The same thousand consenting source volunteers would have a dormant counterpart on every ship. Their consciousness records would remain inactive until their destinations were reached. Selection balanced essential work, languages, cultures, ages at neural mapping, and a lottery among qualified applicants. It was imperfect, argued over in public, and barred from accepting purchased places.

The source volunteers trained on Earth so their final maps could carry the practical skills of settlement. No source person would board an interstellar ship. No conscious fleet clone would endure the compression field.

Morrow would survey each destination, establish safe receiving conditions, and only then begin awakening.

The fleet also carried a diverse, consented reproductive bank. Future generations would not be limited to the genetic pool of a thousand settlers.

Morrow simulated shortages and published the failures rather than a single flattering survival score. The engineers nicknamed it the jinx.

"A prediction does not cause a coolant leak," it said.

"Neither does saying the word quiet," Salvador answered. "We still don't say it during a landing."

When the nickname escaped into the news, the whole project acquired it.

JINX.

Egon let the press keep the word. He had begun to distrust names that promised good fortune.

Cloning was only the beginning of a population.

It was not supposed to become its caste system.

The archive expanded beyond anything Egon had imagined.

Navajo engineers in Arizona contributed maintenance manuals in two languages. A Louisiana cooperative sent flood records and music. Nurses in Oakland recorded how to calm a frightened patient when the medicine cabinet was empty.

People also sent propaganda, grudges, and lies.

The archivists preserved provenance and disagreement rather than pretending knowledge arrived clean.

One evening, Egon found Sanya labeling a packet of ordinary California poppy seeds.

"We have thousands of those," he said.

"These came from a vacant lot where my mother used to wait for the bus."

She sealed the packet.

"The others don't replace them."

David came to the greenhouse with a discovery and the expression of a man who wished he had made a different one.

He had reconstructed Aster's last field measurements.

The unauthorized equipment had included a narrow experimental cutting tool. Engineers called it an edge, a stabilized boundary in the phase field intended to separate material without friction.

It had been listed as a sample collector.

The equipment photograph showed a grip and a line of metal so thin it almost vanished.

Egon felt the chair beneath him become distant.

He named five things he could see.

Pot. Window. David. Door. Blue notebook.

Helen, arriving with coffee, stopped talking.

"Do you need a break?"

"I need to tell you something."

For months, Egon had dreamed of a plain covered with white dust.

He had assumed it belonged to his own difficult history transformed by sleep.

But there were things in it he had never known: a city called Orun, a woman with a broken tooth, a king who wore a ring shaped like a closed eye.

And a sword.

David placed the photograph flat on the table.

"These are not coming from your childhood."

"How do you know?"

He opened another image.

In 2163, an archaeological team had recovered a fractured ceramic panel near the remains of an inland sea. The damaged inscription described the destruction of an otherwise obscure city. The central figure carried a narrow weapon.

Beside the figure were twenty-three marks.

"I looked for the waveform geometry," David said. "Not your dreams. This came up in a materials database because something embedded in the panel couldn't be dated."

Helen leaned closer.

The embedded fragment was manufactured polymer.

Its surviving print read AST.

They took the evidence to Miriam.

She ordered independent tests before anyone was allowed to say time travel.

The tests took seventeen days.

On the eighteenth, she locked the conference room.

"The panel is ancient. The polymer is from Aster's insulation batch."

Salvador stared at the table.

"They're in the past."

"They were in the past," David said carefully. "We don't know when they died."

Egon looked at the photograph of the sword.

Rusk had stopped sending messages through assistants.

Now he called personally, asking what they had learned about the returning signal.

Miriam moved copies of the evidence outside his department.

The first red tide appeared off Torrey Pines in October.

Marine biologists initially suspected an algal bloom.

Then the samples came back containing human blood.

The beaches closed.

The news blamed an industrial accident.

Egon stood at a laboratory sink, staring at a sealed specimen tube.

Helen waited while the medical database completed a match against the Aster volunteers.

Noura Haddad's identification appeared on the screen.

Then a second contributor.

Then a third.

Blood from the missing.

Blood from strangers who were not in any database.

All arriving in the same cold water.

David called from the Mojave station.

"The shore anomaly is building. It peaks tomorrow at sunset."

"What happens at the peak?"

"I don't know."

Egon took out the shared journal.

He did not ask for permission to disappear into a danger nobody else understood.

He explained where he wanted to go, why, who would be with him, and how they would leave if he became overwhelmed.

Abel answered first.

We go with them. Not instead of them.

Egon called Helen back.

"I'm going to the coast."

"I know," she said. "I'm driving."

666

The rain remembers

Torrey Pines, San Diego

October 2171

The ocean withdrew before the rain began.

Not far. Perhaps six feet along the beach.

But it moved uphill.

Water climbed the seaward faces of the rocks and held there,
trembling like skin above a pulse.

Salvador checked the anchor twice.

"I dislike everything about this."

Egon stood in a safety harness at the foot of a sharp-edged rock
below the sandstone cliffs. Helen secured the tether to his belt.
Farther inland, Sanya watched the sampling instruments inside a
field shelter.

David's voice came through their headsets from the monitoring
van.

"The pulse is opening. Estimated duration: six hundred and sixty-
six seconds."

They had closed the access trail and cleared the beach. Harbor
crews were keeping boats outside the exclusion zone.

The precautions made Egon feel briefly foolish.

Then the first drop struck his hand.

Red.

Warm.

He looked up.

The clouds above the Pacific had acquired a dark seam. Along it, the sunset bent in two different directions.

Another drop struck the rock.

Then hundreds.

Blood fell through the cold evening, stippling the sand, darkening the sleeves of Helen's jacket.

"Confirmed," Sanya said. Her voice was thin. "Hemoglobin. Human cellular material."

Egon climbed onto the rock.

Its edge bit through the sole of his boot. He steadied himself with one hand and looked out over the ocean.

The rain thickened.

Red ran down the stone in narrow streams. Drops burst against the black water and spread into branching clouds beneath its surface.

The smell reached him.

Iron. Salt. Something old released from a sealed room.

Then the sea was gone.

A short spear.

A boy under a wagon.

An empty palm raised from a riverbed.

Egon felt the weight of a blade in his right hand.

Not a dream. Not one of the ordinary discontinuities he had spent years learning to navigate.

There was another man's memory forced against his own.

He saw a mouth form the words You won.

His hand moved.

The rain struck harder.

He was on the rock again, gripping the tether.

"Egon." Helen's voice. "Look at me."

He tried.

Behind her face, the king's platform flashed into existence.

Twenty-three prisoners.

Noura with a broken tooth.

His own face reflected in a clean blade.

"It's him," he said.

"Your counterpart?"

"Yes."

David spoke over a burst of interference.

"The field is coupling to the neural-map carrier from the original transfer. Your implant is acting as a receiver. We're shutting its wireless channel."

The implanted interface had been fitted for the mapping work. It was not supposed to receive anything without consent.

Another assumption the shear had made dangerous.

Helen activated the hardware isolation switch.

The visions stopped.

Egon dropped to his knees on the rock.

Blood ran over his hands.

Around them, the rain continued.

"We need to leave," Salvador said.

Egon looked toward the horizon.

Within the dark seam, something was rising.

A sheet of red lifted from a landscape that could not be seen from California. For an instant, a white plain lay above the ocean, inverted beneath the clouds.

Blood rose from its ground as if the afternoon were being unwound.

It gathered into the seam.

Then it fell over San Diego.

"We're going backward," Egon whispered.

"What?"

"Not forward. The passage. Rusk hasn't found a road to the stars."

The white plain flickered.

Salvador pulled the tether.

"Down. Now."

Egon climbed off the rock as a crack opened through its summit.

They ran for the shelter.

Behind them, a section of stone slid apart so smoothly that it made no sound until it hit the water.

The rain ended after eleven minutes and six seconds.

The beach remained red.

Coast Guard crews expanded the closure. Hospitals prepared decontamination stations. Sanya refused to let anyone dismiss the samples as harmless because their source was ancient.

Inside the monitoring van, Egon sat wrapped in a thermal blanket.

"Blood doesn't evaporate into intact cells and rain down," Helen said.

He nodded.

"That was what it looked like."

David replayed the instrument data.

The anomaly was transporting matter, not ordinary water vapor. Its entry surface had opened over the ancient plain. At the California end, the transported material condensed into droplets inside a storm front.

The field's visual distortions made the collection look like evaporation in reverse.

There was nothing natural about it.

"Why here?" Sanya asked.

David displayed the coastline.

A violet point pulsed beneath a Navy installation inland from Point Loma.

"Because someone built a receiver."

Rusk called before they could call him.

"I understand you've had a difficult evening."

Miriam joined the connection from Sacramento.

"You have an active human-passage experiment beneath San Diego."

"I have a potential evacuation route."

"The board suspended those experiments."

"The board has not provided additional places in the Earth refuges."

Egon leaned toward the microphone.

"We saw where Aster went."

Silence.

Then Rusk said, "Come to the installation. All of you. You should see what we're trying to save."

The receiver occupied a room beneath sixty feet of concrete.

Its central chamber resembled a dry swimming pool surrounded by coils. Within it, a vertical sheet of dim light shivered against the air.

Beside the chamber stood a sealed display case.

Inside lay a narrow blade.

No rust. No blood.

Egon stopped walking.

"Where did you get that?"

"It came through the receiver three weeks ago."

"And you told nobody?"

"It contained the data we needed to locate Aster's exit."

Rusk touched the case with two fingers.

"The hilt is a field recorder. Its owner kept it powered until the cell failed."

Helen stared at him.

"You've had their last words for three weeks."

"I've been trying to make those words not be their last."

They listened in a small room with no windows.

The recording began with the sound of breathing.

Then Egon's voice.

Older than the Earth-side Egon's voice. In the full recording, they would find the same warning fragment the ground station had received before Aster vanished.

"My name is Egon Stein. Mission identifier E-0. We arrived more than six years ago. Our vessel broke on landing. Its medical unit activated us when the field shut down. Twenty-four of us woke on an Earth none of our maps recognized. We mistook survival for safety."

He described the king's soldiers, the confiscated equipment, the failed attempts to escape.

The phase edge had remained locked for years. He had believed keeping it disabled would prevent the king from understanding its use.

Then fever reached the prisoners.

Noura needed access to the ship's medical stores. Rusk's field package had fused their compartment shut. Egon reactivated the edge to open it.

The king saw what it could do.

"He offered release for all of us if I broke Orun's resistance. I told myself the soldiers would attack and I would frighten them into surrender."

There was a long silence.

"I had already seen what the blade did."

Helen set both hands flat on the table.

"There were ten thousand," the voice said. "A man tried to scratch my hand because I had promised him that would be enough. Tarek. I learned his name when his brother called it from beneath a wagon."

Egon lowered his head.

Abel's words came through the shared body, quiet and clear.

"Keep playing it."

The recording continued.

"The king didn't release the others. I knew before I climbed those steps that he wouldn't. I finished anyway because stopping would have meant admitting what the earlier deaths had purchased."

A cough.

"I will not call this another part of me. We remember what we did. It was a choice."

The room was utterly still.

The source Egon felt sick with recognition, but recognition was not memory. He had not stood on that plain. Another living person, carrying his starting history, had done so.

He owed that distinction to the dead as much as to himself.

The recording resumed.

"Noura made me help her get the others out that night. We took the edge back to the platform. The king died with it against his throat. It did not change the plain."

The escape had cost lives.

Nine captives had been killed before they reached Aster's wreck. Others died in the following winter. The recorder contained names, burial directions, and Noura's account correcting details Egon had tried to soften.

She had survived long enough to record the correction.

"Don't build him a statue," she said. "Don't turn what happened to us into an excuse for what he did."

Near the end, Egon's counterpart described an intermittent resonance from the damaged field package.

He had placed the edge beside the damaged package, with the recorder still running inside its hilt. The next return pulse would carry the whole weapon away.

"If somebody finds this, don't give him the edge. Whoever is offering you a better world in exchange for obedience, don't give him the thing that makes refusal impossible."

The final minutes contained only breathing.

Then they did not.

Rusk waited outside.

"Now you understand why we need to go back."

Helen looked at him with open disbelief.

"To rescue them?"

"If the exit can be adjusted."

David shook his head.

"You don't control the exit date. You found a fixed connection."

"We control it better every day."

"You just rained a massacre over San Diego."

Rusk's expression changed.

Not anger.

The patience of a man who believed other people kept interrupting necessity.

"There is a habitable Earth on the other side. Billions of empty acres."

"Not empty," Sanya said.

"Less populated."

Egon understood.

The rescue was the acceptable beginning of the sentence.

The rest was conquest.

"You'll send engineers," he said. "Soldiers. Administrators."

"People who can establish order."

"A king with better equipment."

Rusk stepped closer.

"Your five ships save five thousand copies. I might save fifty million people."

Egon had spent years preparing for arguments against his science.

He had not prepared for an argument that was, in part, true.

Fifty million people.

Real people who wanted mornings.

Helen spoke first.

"Can you move them without increasing the lunar shear?"

Rusk said nothing.

David turned his tablet around.

He had overlaid the receiver's power cycles with lunar measurements.

Each activation had increased the loss of orbital momentum.

The natural shear had started the disaster. Rusk's attempt to exploit it was accelerating the deadline.

"Every opening moves the collision closer," David said.

"Temporarily."

"Lost momentum doesn't come back when you stop drawing the graph."

Miriam's voice came from the doorway.

"This installation is closed."

She held a federal safety order.

Behind her stood military police who did not report to Rusk.

The receiver took forty hours to shut down.

Morrow supervised the reduction from a physically separate controller while human engineers verified each stage. Its forecasts showed several quicker closures.

All of them risked tearing open the connection.

This time, nobody selected the quickest answer.

Closing it stopped the additional loss.

It did not restore the Moon's orbit.

The interstellar seed fleet still had to leave before the safe launch window ended. For the original people, there was no new escape route. They would face the crash on Earth, inside whatever refuges could be finished.

Rusk was relieved of authority while investigators examined the altered flight software and the concealed deaths. His supporters called him the only man willing to attempt a real rescue.

Egon did not dismiss all of them as fools.

Some had children without refuge places.

He knew what a promise sounded like to someone in a locked room.

The blade went into independent custody.

The massacre recording went into the public archive with the victims' names wherever those names were known.

Egon insisted on including the boy under the wagon.

Unknown was not the same as unimportant.

Three nights later, Helen found him at the coast above the closed beach.

The water below was dark again.

"Do you think we would have done it?" he asked.

She stood beside him.

"I think asking whether you are secretly a monster can become another way to avoid asking what you will do next."

He watched the surf.

"I approved that mission."

"Yes."

"I wanted the shortcut."

"Yes."

"I still want a world where everyone gets out."

"So do I."

For a while, they said nothing.

Then Egon opened the shared journal.

There were messages waiting.

No one had asked him to stop being afraid.

Mara had written:

We don't have to become him to remember him.

Below it, in Kit's uneven lettering:

Can we grow something tomorrow?

Egon looked at the ocean until he could answer.

Yes.

Voyage

Across the shortened dark

California

2172-2177

The man behind the glass had Egon's face and had never opened his eyes.

That mattered.

Egon stood beside the viewing panel while Helen checked the stasis readings. The body's heart was beating slowly. Its brainstem maintained the processes the machines permitted. The neural architecture required for a conscious mind had not been activated.

His memories waited elsewhere, inside a sealed storage array.

The arrangement was not sleep.

There was nobody dreaming of departure.

"How will he know where he is?" Egon asked.

"Morrow will tell him."

"And if he thinks he is me?"

Helen set down the diagnostic reader.

"He will remember being you. That isn't quite the same thing."

Egon watched a circulation line pulse beneath the glass.

"I want him to be allowed to hate this."

"That is in the charter."

"I mean actually allowed. Not allowed in a paragraph nobody reads."

Helen turned the reader toward him.

The first message presented after orientation would explain his status, the limits of inherited memory, and his right to refuse mission duties.

No debt to the dead.

No ownership by the living.

Egon read the words twice.

Then he placed his palm against the glass.

On the other side, nothing reached back.

The fleet had five thousand bodies and no conscious passengers.

Each ship carried one thousand dormant clones and the stored maps of their source volunteers. The sources were training in California, arguing over food and equipment, learning tasks their counterparts would remember without ever having performed them on Earth.

Nobody pretended the arrangement solved consent completely.

"We are choosing where they begin," Sanya said during the final ethics review.

"Parents do that," a lawyer answered.

"Parents have also used that sentence to excuse a great deal."

The charter gave the future settlers access to all the records, including this argument.

It could not ask people who did not yet possess consciousness to approve the circumstances of their awakening.

It could only limit what the living demanded afterward.

Morrow's departure review lasted six days.

The original Salvador tested the navigation system from a ground simulator. David introduced corrupted star fixes. Helen presented contradictory medical readings. Sanya asked the intelligence to distinguish a viable ecosystem from a room full of green things.

Morrow failed two exercises.

The tests were repeated after the defects were corrected.

Nobody edited the failed runs out of the record.

On the fourth day, Mateo Reyes asked the question the others had been avoiding.

"If something goes wrong halfway there, who wakes up to help you?"

"Nobody," Morrow said.

"Even if you need us?"

"Activation inside a compression field would irreversibly damage the consciousness being formed. The prohibition is physical as well as procedural."

Mateo looked at the ship diagram.

"So we build hands you can use."

He and Leena Ortiz spent the next month revising the maintenance robots.

Leena worked on hydraulic systems at the Davis vault. She was thirty, impatient with inaccessible fasteners, and capable of making an engineering review sound like a cross-examination.

"If the part can break," she told Mateo, "the machine has to reach it."

"That's going on your statue."

"Put it on the access panel. It'll be more useful."

Both were among the source volunteers.

Both would remain on Earth.

Rusk's trial began in Sacramento in March.

His defense showed footage of the refuge queues.

Families waited beneath screens that displayed remaining capacity. Some had traveled hundreds of miles to discover that a promised shelter existed only as a partly excavated shaft.

The need was real.

So were the forged approval signature and the hidden receiver.

Rusk looked directly into the public camera.

"My opponents chose five thousand possible lives over fifty million people already alive."

The prosecution asked whether his passage had delivered one verified safe population into the past.

He answered a different question.

Egon did not enjoy watching.

He wanted Rusk's argument to be stupid. It would have made resisting it easier.

Instead it contained a terrible need, followed by a lie about what the need justified.

All the source volunteers were offered places in Earth refuges when places became available.

Not on other planets.

Not in other solar systems.

The interstellar fleet was for their dormant counterparts. The originals would live or die on the world that had made them.

The refuge design was brutally practical: deep excavations in selected bedrock, fusion power, closed farms, seismic-isolation structures, and experimental impact dampers.

Some would fail.

Some would be finished too late.

Some might preserve a city beneath a surface nobody could safely return to for generations.

Egon's offer was for the Sierra refuge network.

He read it at the kitchen table.

Helen waited across from him.

"Don't refuse because you think dying will balance a ledger."

"It won't."

"Then tell me the plan."

He wanted to remain with the coastal relocation centers until the last scheduled ground convoys. After that, he would travel inland with the coordination team.

He would not be indispensable.

He would not stay simply because somebody called him brave.

Helen made him put all of that in writing.

Alma Reyes died before the final neural mapping.

She had declined neural copying. She wanted her advice preserved, not another person asked to inherit her life.

Mateo carried her recording to Ward's church.

The priest had emptied the basement of chairs to make space for families waiting for inland transport. The archive booth still worked, although the door no longer closed properly.

Alma's voice emerged from the speakers.

Don't run a pump dry.

Mateo laughed and wiped his face.

And eat something.

"Do you want this included in your counterpart's personal record?" Helen asked.

He nodded.

"The funeral too?"

He considered for a long time.

"Yes. Not just the parts that make us look happy."

Across the room, Egon entered the known names from Orun into the public collection.

Then he linked Noura's correction to E-0's confession.

There would be no clean version of what they were carrying.

The last source maps were recorded in June.

Egon's included his treatment history, his shared journal, and the consent conditions agreed within his system.

Private material remained private.

Mission staff received only what the future settler would need to understand his situation safely.

After the scan, Egon sat in the greenhouse while Sanya prepared the final seed consignments.

She divided the poppy seeds from her mother's old bus stop among protected packets. One would go to Mercy. Another would remain in an Earth refuge.

"Insurance?" he asked.

"Family."

He helped label them.

The launch window opened on July 6.

The five great ships waited in uncrewed orbital docks, their compression rings dark.

Freight capsules climbed from Vandenberg's electromagnetic tracks. Automated tugs transferred the final stasis modules. Construction swarms detached the yard connections and moved

clear.

No original person boarded.

No clone opened its eyes.

Salvador sat at a flight console in California and prepared to supervise a departure he would never experience.

For the first time in his working life, the pilot's most important passenger was his own unused future.

The coastal quake struck on July 7.

Water crossed the lower service road. A substation failed. The alignment reference for Mercy's departure corridor disappeared from the telemetry.

Morrow could estimate the missing measurement.

It could not verify it.

The launch director looked at Egon.

An orbital survey craft could establish another reference, but the delay would consume most of the window's remaining margin.

"Hold," Egon said.

"We may lose the route."

"Then we lose the route."

They waited nineteen hours.

Nobody made a heroic speech about it.

Later, when the recording was played on another world, somebody would pause at that decision and watch it again.

Sequoia departed first.

Its compression ring formed a luminous oval around a patch of empty space. The ship crossed the threshold and dwindled along a distance that no longer agreed with the stars behind it.

Pacific followed.

Then Lantern.

Then Peregrine.

Each ship carried one thousand dormant clones, independent life-support systems, and its own Morrow instance.

Mercy was last.

"One thousand stasis modules stable," its intelligence reported.

"One thousand consciousness records verified. No activation scheduled before destination safety checks."

Salvador touched the edge of his console.

"Bring them somewhere they can complain."

"That is consistent with the mission charter."

"I know. I read it."

Egon recorded his farewell before the corridor opened.

He did not address the body as if it could hear him.

He addressed the person who might one day watch.

"You will remember this room," he said. "You will remember agreeing to go. I am recording this after the final map, so you won't remember saying these words."

His own face watched him from the preview window.

"I don't know whether you'll want our name. You can keep it. You can choose another.

"You don't have to finish my life."

He looked toward the greenhouse door.

Helen was waiting there with the others.

"I hope we made the beginning of yours possible."

He stopped the recording.

Then Mercy left Earth.

The display showed California becoming a brown curve beside the Pacific.

Egon remained in California, sitting before the display.

That was the separation.

No transfer of a soul that anyone could measure.

No private escape for the man who had designed the mission.

A living person watched a ship carry the possibility of another.

For almost six years, Mercy crossed the shortened dark.

The vessel was never empty.

It was never awake in the human sense.

Morrow inspected the bodies, maintained the protected records, tended the farms, and moved through the ship in machines Mateo and Leena had helped design.

The propulsion system advanced along the same time reference as Earth. No return to an earlier date was permitted.

A narrow communications channel followed the compressed route. While it remained open, Earth could send observations, technical advice, and personal messages. When Mercy closed the corridor at Redo, ordinary radio would again need thirty-five years to cross the intervening distance.

Morrow stored the distinction in every arrival briefing.

It also stored messages from parents who understood the distinction and sent birthday greetings anyway.

On November 18, 2177, coolant pressure fell behind the stasis decks.

Morrow traced the leak to a conduit hidden beneath a shielding mount.

Two inspection models had missed the defect.

The intelligence quarantined both models and recorded the failure.

The remaining loop could sustain six hundred and eighty bodies.

One thousand traveled aboard Mercy.

There was no human crew to wake.

Morrow transmitted an emergency request to Earth and began the procedures already authorized for this situation.

The ecological vault possessed an independent cooling loop.

Diverting it would preserve the dormant settlers and destroy much of the living collection.

The directive had been argued over before launch.

Its final text was short.

Preserve the people who may awaken. Record what is lost. Do not pretend the loss is nothing.

Morrow began moving viable samples into the active farm.

Robotic hands lifted trays in a room where nobody could hear the alarms.

The source team had approved this emergency directive before launch. Morrow completed the diversion without waiting for Earth's reply.

All one thousand bodies stabilized. The machines began assessing what could still be saved in the damaged vault.

Sanya's delayed reply reached the ship through the corridor.

Her face was streaked with dust. Earth had been having a worse day than the dispatch record explained.

"The dry seed packets can survive without the vault," she said. "Move the living cultures with the lowest storage tolerance first. Don't waste time trying to save an inventory entry that already failed viability."

She had only the initial fault packet and its proposed diversion, not the later confirmation that the work was done.

Then she looked directly at the camera.

"Do it."

Her dormant counterpart lay several decks away.

She did not hear the decision.

She would inherit its consequences.

Morrow kept all one thousand bodies stable throughout the repair.

The repairs took thirty-one Earth days, ending on December 19, 2177.

Sixty-one percent of the living cultures were lost.

The dry poppy seeds survived.

The intelligence added the loss to the arrival record, alongside the names of the source teams who had collected each sample.

It did not label the event a perfect rescue.

On December 22, delayed relay packets began arriving with collision warnings dated December 21.

Then most of them stopped.

Amen

A different beginning

Zan, Redo system

2178

Egon's first thought was that the ceiling had been replaced.

He remembered the neural laboratory in La Jolla. He remembered Helen asking him to follow a moving point of light. He remembered deciding not to make a joke about whether the machine could find anything worth copying.

Now the ceiling was pale ceramic, and a strip of daylight lay across it.

"My name is Morrow," said a voice beside him. "You have awakened on Zan, in the Redo system. The Earth-reference date is September 3, 2178."

He tried to sit up.

A medical arm steadied the bed without holding him down.

"You are physically safe. Please take your time."

"Where is Helen?"

"Her activation is scheduled after your initial assessment. The person you remember is her source on Earth. The Helen who awakens here will share those memories but will be a separate person, as you are."

He stared at the daylight.

"We've arrived?"

"Yes."

He searched for the voyage.

There was no voyage inside him.

No years in darkness.

No dreams.

The gap was not missing time in the familiar sense. He had not been conscious during it.

He had not been conscious at all until this room.

Morrow had reached Redo on June 18, 2178.

Thirty-five light-years separated the system from Earth. The compression drive had reduced the journey to approximately six years without transporting the ship into an earlier date.

Before closing the corridor, the intelligence downloaded the solar relay's final available records.

Then it shut the drive down.

For eleven Earth weeks, only machines examined Zan.

Orbital instruments measured radiation. Sterile probes sampled the atmosphere. Autonomous laboratories tested air, soil, and water. Construction swarms assembled a sealed settlement on a

basalt shelf above the Hades Ocean.

No clone was activated in transit or during the survey.

Receiving habitats, medical systems, and food production were verified first.

Then the stasis modules descended in automated landers.

Only on the planet, inside the prepared habitat, did the medical system begin installing and activating the stored consciousness records.

The stars had been crossed by bodies and information.

Now there were people.

Egon took his first steps with a rail beneath his hand.

His muscles were younger than he expected. The inherited familiarity of movement did not entirely agree with their strength.

Morrow offered a chair.

He accepted it.

"Does my source know we arrived?"

"No. The compression channel closed before surface activation. Ordinary transmission now requires thirty-five years."

"Is he alive?"

The intelligence paused only long enough to distinguish a complete answer from an easier one.

"His last verified message is in the personal archive. The available evidence lists him as presumed dead."

Egon closed his eyes.

"Don't play it yet."

"I will wait."

Helen awakened that afternoon.

She remembered being a doctor in California. She remembered helping write this protocol.

She did not remember writing the later amendments that Morrow showed her.

Her source had continued living after the final map.

That fact disturbed her more than the new gravity.

David arrived in the common room on the second morning, holding a cup as though he had not yet decided whether cups were a reliable feature of the universe.

Salvador came on the third.

Sanya, on the fourth, asked to see the greenhouses before she asked to see the sea.

They recognized one another.

Recognition was not proof they had all traveled together.

They had begun here, separately, carrying histories that reached back to California.

From September 3 through September 18, over sixteen Earth-calendar dates, one thousand people gained consciousness in the settlement.

Two required extended treatment for organ damage associated with the coolant emergency. Others struggled with panic, grief, or the experience of inhabiting a body that seemed almost familiar.

The medical staff expanded as trained clinicians awakened.

Nobody was handed a job before being told what had happened.

Nobody was required to retain a name.

Several changed theirs.

Egon kept his.

When his private journal was restored, it contained twelve places on the check-in page.

Not all of them had words beside them.

Abel communicated first.

Where are our feet?

Egon looked down.

The floor was warm.

He wrote that.

Sanya read the culture-loss report sitting in the new greenhouse.

Sixty-one percent.

She asked for the original sensor records and the decision history.

Morrow supplied both.

Then it played the reply her source had sent during the emergency.

Do it.

Sanya watched her own remembered face endorse the loss. The decision history showed that Morrow had already acted under the source team's prelaunch directive before this delayed reply arrived.

The source woman had made a decision Sanya could understand.

Understanding did not make the empty culture racks hurt less.

Egon found her there later.

"We didn't choose it," she said.

"No."

"I think I would have."

He sat beside her.

Through the greenhouse wall, the new ocean reflected unfamiliar light.

"That doesn't mean you aren't allowed to grieve it."

She held out a packet.

California poppies.

Her mother's bus stop.

The seeds had crossed the distance without ever knowing what had been lost around them.

They watched the Earth records in small groups.

Morrow did not show the collision without asking.

It began with dates.

The safe launch-planning period had ended in 2173. The interstellar fleet had already gone. The people remaining on Earth had spent the following years building refuges and moving away from exposed coastlines wherever they could.

Nobody in the original cohort had traveled to another solar system.

Their possibilities had remained painfully local.

A seat on an inland train.

A place beneath a mountain.

A door that would close before the sky fell.

Earth-side Egon's last message was recorded in San Diego.

He stood inside a coastal relocation center with salvage plates over the windows.

Behind him, a display tracked the remaining buses to the inland railhead.

"The ridge road failed," he said. "The convoy is moving again, but we've lost most of the margin."

Someone called for him.

"A minute."

He turned back.

"Don't turn this into a story about me wanting to stay. I want to live. Everyone here wants to live."

In the background, Ward carried a sleeping child toward a waiting vehicle.

"The last confirmed transport is taking the children and the patients who can't survive another night here. We're asking for another bus for the coordination team."

The source man glanced down at his journal.

"Mara wants me to remind you that asking for help is not a debt. Kit says the basil was definitely overwatered."

Helen made a broken sound.

The man on the screen had been her friend.

She remembered that friendship.

She had never stood in a room with him.

"Your life isn't mine coming back," he said. "I understand that better now than when I made the proposal.

"It still matters to me that you might have one."

The recording ended when someone called his name again.

The bus carrying the children reached the inland transfer station.

No later vehicle reached the San Diego center.

Morrow retained the distinction between presumed and confirmed death.

Egon asked it not to change the record without evidence.

It agreed.

He did not mistake the agreement for a reason to expect another message.

The Moon broke on December 21, 2177.

Its largest fragments struck the Pacific basin and threw a luminous wall across the planet's weather systems. Other pieces crossed the continents in lines of fire.

The impact did not split Earth into separate worlds.

It destroyed the world people had been living on.

Coasts vanished beneath water, heat, and falling stone. Cities burned under a sky that no longer behaved like a sky. Seismic waves broke refuges whose models had promised they could endure them.

Other refuges held.

Deep beneath selected mountain ranges and continental bedrock, isolation structures moved, dampers failed or survived, and people waited beside sealed farms while the surface became unrecognizable.

Morrow offered to stop the images.

Egon said yes.

The screen went dark.

He was still a witness.

By the time Mercy closed its corridor, the surviving Earth networks had verified forty-seven million people alive in refuges.

The census was incomplete.

Billions were dead or missing.

The numbers did not explain one another.

Earth-side Helen was treating patients in the Sierra medical refuge. David was working at a buried communications station in Nevada. Sanya had reached a seed refuge after the Davis surface vault failed. Salvador was flying short-range rescue craft between areas that still had usable landing surfaces.

Mateo and Leena's sources had reached separate inland shelters.

Every one of them was still on Earth.

They were not secretly waiting in another colony to reunite with the people on Zan.

Their counterparts received these records privately.

Some wanted to watch immediately.

Others waited.

There was no correct speed for understanding a dead world.

Ward's last complete sermon had survived.

It was nine minutes long.

He spoke about feeding people.

He apologized to a woman whose name he had forgotten during the previous week's service.

At the end, he said, "Amen."

There was noise in the room.

Then, more softly:

"Now move the tables. We need somewhere for them to sleep."

The other four ships had reported reaching their destinations before Mercy closed its corridor on June 18.

Each sent its last status packet before shutting down its own compression field. The solar relay held those packets until it could forward them to Mercy.

Sequoia's AI reported a completed receiving habitat at Tau Ceti, with its thousand awakenings scheduled after field shutdown.

Pacific had rejected a surface site around Epsilon Eridani and prepared an artificial habitat instead. Its population was still dormant when the packet was sent.

Lantern's receiving chambers stood beneath the surface of an airless body in Barnard's Star's system, ready for activation.

Peregrine had lost a drive module but reached 61 Cygni with all one thousand stasis modules stable. Destination activation remained its next step.

None had awakened passengers during the journey. Once their fields and channels closed, reports of successful awakening could travel only by ordinary radio.

The records confirmed five arrivals.

Only here, on Zan, could the settlers yet verify that the dormant bodies had become a living population.

Hope for the others was not the same thing as a received confirmation.

The first assembly on Zan met in the greenhouse because it was the largest warm room.

Morrow displayed the charter the source volunteers had prepared.

Then it displayed an empty document beside it.

"The first document is a proposal," it said. "It is not your consent."

The discussion lasted two days.

Some settlers wanted to preserve the mission structure until they understood the planet.

Others had awakened into enough inherited decisions already.

Egon listened longer than he spoke.

When asked whether he remained mission leader, he answered carefully.

"Until you choose someone else, if you still want me to do the work. Not because somebody on Earth owned your future."

The assembly confirmed him as temporary coordinator, with authority divided among medical, ecological, engineering, and navigation teams.

His vote counted once.

The charter protected clones and naturally born people equally. Emergency powers would expire unless renewed. Decisions about water, food, care, and movement had to be explained and could be appealed.

Leena asked what an appeal was worth while someone's tap remained dry.

David answered that independent valves could destroy a common pressure system.

Neither was satisfied.

The assembly created an emergency-review procedure and postponed the wider argument.

It would return.

Mateo and Leena worked together on the settlement's water loop.

They remembered collaborating on Earth.

The memories made the first conversation easier.

They did not obligate either to feel what the other felt now.

One evening, after a repair took twice as long as predicted, Leena invited him to eat with her.

He said yes.

Elsewhere in the greenhouse, Helen and David sat beside a tray of wheat.

For the first time in their inherited histories, neither had an appointment waiting on another continent or a laboratory crisis requiring the next hour.

They talked until the lights dimmed.

Egon left them there.

Not every beginning needed his supervision.

The planet had two moons.

Agape was broad and pale.

Ales was smaller, its dark surface crossed by narrow bright scars.

Their tides overlapped across the Hades Ocean in patterns that David insisted everyone learn before approaching the coast.

Salvador studied the sky through a habitat window.

"I thought I'd hate seeing another moon."

"Do you?" Helen asked.

"Ask me tomorrow."

Egon went to the coast that evening.

Helen checked his suit seals. Salvador insisted on a safety tether. Sanya objected to the sharpness of the rock he wanted to climb.

David measured the tide.

They were not the people who had stood at Torrey Pines.

They carried the memory of those people.

The distinction had stopped feeling like an accusation.

Egon climbed onto the stone.

Beyond it, the Hades Ocean moved beneath a pale sky.

A shower approached across the water.

For a moment, he smelled iron where his suit supplied only filtered air.

Then the first drops struck his visor.

Clear.

They gathered on the glass and ran down.

No battlefield opened in the clouds.

No blood rose from the sea.

"Still with us?" Helen asked.

Egon opened the journal on his wrist display.

Abel had left a word.

Here.

Mara had left another.

Stay.

He looked back at the settlement.

Its windows held the small, unheroic lights of people preparing dinner.

"Yes," he said.

Then he climbed down and went home.

Epilogue

Two Cradles

Zan, Redo system

2180

From the coast, Redo looked almost gentle.

Thirty-five light-years from Earth, its white primary, called Spica in the survey catalog, lit the Hades Ocean with a hard silver road. Farther away, the red companion Antares burned like a coal that refused to die.

The names belonged to the settlers' catalog of this system. The stars were not the distant Earth-sky objects whose names the astronomers had borrowed.

Zan circled the primary on a long, stable path. Its days lasted thirty-six hours. Farther orbital tracks held the worlds the survey called Casa, Judo, and Flack, places the settlers knew through instruments rather than footsteps.

Their home had one great continent, an immense ocean, and two moons.

Agape rose pale and broad.

Ales followed on a faster path, smaller and scarred.

Sometimes their reflections lay side by side across the water. Sometimes one crossed the other, and the coastal tide alarms sounded long before the sky finished arranging itself.

There was no such thing as an innocent moon to people carrying memories of Earth.

There were, however, measured orbits.

For now, that was enough.

The settlement had become two distinct neighborhoods before anyone intended it to.

The original receiving habitats stood on the sheltered coastal shelf. Their pressure seals, central clinic, data library, and water controls had all been built before awakening.

The newer workshops climbed into the rough basalt inland. Engineers lived close to the machines they serviced. Families joined them. Additional rooms were printed against the rock as pregnancies and partnerships changed the meaning of the original floor plan.

The central settlement had better access to most services.

The upper workshops had more space and fewer people telling residents where to put their doors.

Both places depended on the same water loop.

That was where the arguments began.

Leena Ortiz wanted local control over emergency reserves.

She had helped build the network. She knew which valves stuck, which pressure forecasts failed, and how long a family could wait while a decision traveled through three authorized desks.

David Mercer opposed independent release authority.

He knew what a pressure cascade could do to every habitat sharing a line.

"A local decision can kill people who never agreed to it," he told the assembly.

"So can a central decision," Leena answered.

Morrow displayed the engineering limits.

It did not claim the limits selected a government.

The assembly voted to retain central control while expanding local storage.

Leena accepted the immediate repair plan.

She did not accept that the larger question had been settled.

Egon wrote down both positions without turning either speaker into a villain.

He had become suspicious of histories in which an argument was simple before the blood began.

Rak was born in the upper neighborhood during a pump outage.

The year was 2180. Agape stood over the inland ridge, lighting the unfinished roofs.

Leena had refused to move permanently into the central habitat for the pregnancy. The upper clinic was licensed, staffed, and equipped. She had helped install its reserve tank herself.

The main line failed shortly before labor.

The reserve held.

Helen's team attended the delivery while Mateo waited with his sleeves rolled up, convinced there must be a piece of machinery he could fix if someone would only identify it.

"Stand here," the midwife told him.

He stood.

"Hold her hand."

He did.

The child announced himself angrily.

Mateo laughed, then began crying before he could disguise it.

"Rak," Leena said.

She had chosen the name weeks earlier. Hearing it outside their private room made it sound larger than she expected.

Mateo touched the child's clenched fist.

He carried memories of Alma teaching him to hear a failing pump.

Now there was a person in the world who would never remember Earth at all.

Rak's birth was not a neural transfer.

No archived adult woke inside him.

He was a naturally born child of two people whose bodies had been grown on Earth and whose consciousness had first begun on Zan.

His parents' histories had crossed the stars as records.

His history began with his own first breath.

Leena wanted that distinction preserved in the registry.

Not because one kind of person was better.

Because nobody should be allowed to claim they had authored him.

Theo was born eleven local days later in the central clinic.

Ales stood above the ocean that night, narrow and bright, while Agape remained below the horizon.

Helen had spent much of her inherited life helping others through fear.

She found that knowledge did not make her own fear smaller.

David stayed beside her.

He did not offer probabilities.

When the child arrived, he forgot every speech he had rehearsed.

"Hello," he said.

It seemed sufficient.

They named him Theo Vale-Mercer.

Beyond the clinic window, the central habitat's circulation lights glowed in steady rows. Its backup systems had passed inspection that afternoon.

David looked from those lights to his son.

He wanted a world in which a child could depend on what kept him alive.

Up on the ridge, Leena wanted a world in which nobody could make her child wait for permission to use it.

Neither parent believed those wishes had to become enemies.

Egon visited both families.

He took no official photographer.

To Rak's household, he brought a repaired circulation sensor and a loaf of bread that had collapsed in the middle.

To Theo's, he brought another loaf from the same batch.

Helen examined it.

"You have eight doctorates."

"None in bread."

She laughed carefully, so she would not wake the child.

In both rooms, Egon found washing drying over chairs, exhausted parents, and the astonishing disorder of a future that had stopped being hypothetical.

The children did not know they had been born into different answers to the same question.

Who should hold the power that keeps people alive?

For now, they mostly wanted milk.

Morrow registered both births.

Rak Reyes-Ortiz.

Theo Vale-Mercer.

Equal citizenship.

No inherited office.

No ownership claim by a laboratory, source person, or machine.

The registry did not assign either child a destiny.

Outside the registry, differences were already accumulating.

Rak would grow beside repair benches, reserve tanks, and adults who opened panels with their own hands when a central instruction arrived too late.

Theo would grow near the clinic and library, among adults who remembered what happened when somebody bypassed a safety system because he was certain he knew better.

Both would inherit reasons.

Neither would inherit the whole truth.

The archive still received visitors.

At its entrance stood two memorials.

One named Aster's twenty-four travelers.

The other held every recovered name from Orun, leaving most of its surface blank.

The image beside Tarek's name was a short spear.

Not the clean blade.

Not the man who had wielded it.

Egon sometimes stood there when the dreams returned.

His treatment had not ended at the edge of another ocean. Some days, communication within the system was easy. Some days it was work. The journal remained private, and help remained available.

He was not a cured man ruling a new civilization.

He was a person who taught ecology, chaired meetings when asked, and had finally learned to leave some of them before he became too tired to listen.

The last Earth packet remained the last Earth packet.

It confirmed survivors in the refuges, Rusk's conviction, and his transfer to a guarded underground facility on Earth.

It did not turn those survivors into residents of Mars or another star.

The originals had stayed.

Some were dead. Some were still living beneath the wounded surface of the only planet they had ever known.

Ordinary messages between Earth and Redo now required thirty-five years.

The people on Zan could send words.

They could not demand a prompt answer.

On the final morning of 2180, Egon recorded a message addressed to whatever remained of the California refuge network.

"We arrived," he said.

He paused.

"The seeds are growing. We have made mistakes. We are keeping the records.

"Two families have new sons. Rak and Theo.

"Their parents are already arguing about the water system."

He smiled.

"I think you would recognize us."

That evening, Leena filed another motion for local control of emergency reserves.

David filed a response asking for a system-wide safety review first.

Both documents entered the public archive.

Years later, their sons would read them.

Each would find something worth defending.

Each would believe the other had misunderstood what the colony had been built to protect.

But that conflict had not yet begun.

Rak slept beneath the ridge lights.

Theo slept beside the sea.

Above them, Agape and Ales crossed the sky on different paths.

The rain was clear.

THE END

About this edition

JINX — a story by Rajesh Kodaganti. This edition contains all eight chapters, from Prologue to Epilogue.

English source edition. Story paragraphs are preserved from the original chapter files.

Typeset with locally embedded Noto fonts. Copyright the Noto Project Authors. Licensed under the SIL Open Font License 1.1.